

Steelmen stop Middies for third time

By BOB MCDONALD
Morning Journal Correspondent

GRAFTON — The third time isn't always the charm, but that didn't stop the Midview Middies from trying.

After losing twice in the regular season to the Lorain Steelmen, the Middies looked to advance in the Division I Districts with a triumph over their Erie Shore Conference foes.

The momentum seemed off-setting for both teams, since the Middies played in front of their home crowd, while Lorain played with full knowledge that it might be their last as a school.

Midview built a 25-17 lead going into the half, but the Steelmen surged in the second half, and snatched the ballgame out the hands of the Middies, 42-39.

"We didn't get too many points in the second half," said Midview coach Ray Verba. "We missed foul shots and some nice shots inside. I think that's what killed us."

"I was very disappointed in the first half," said Lorain coach John Rositano. "The second half we made some adjustments. Give credit to both the players and coaches."

The Middies were able to pull out to an 8-3 lead early. The Steelmen came within 2 points at 10-8 but Anthony Stacey chipped in 5

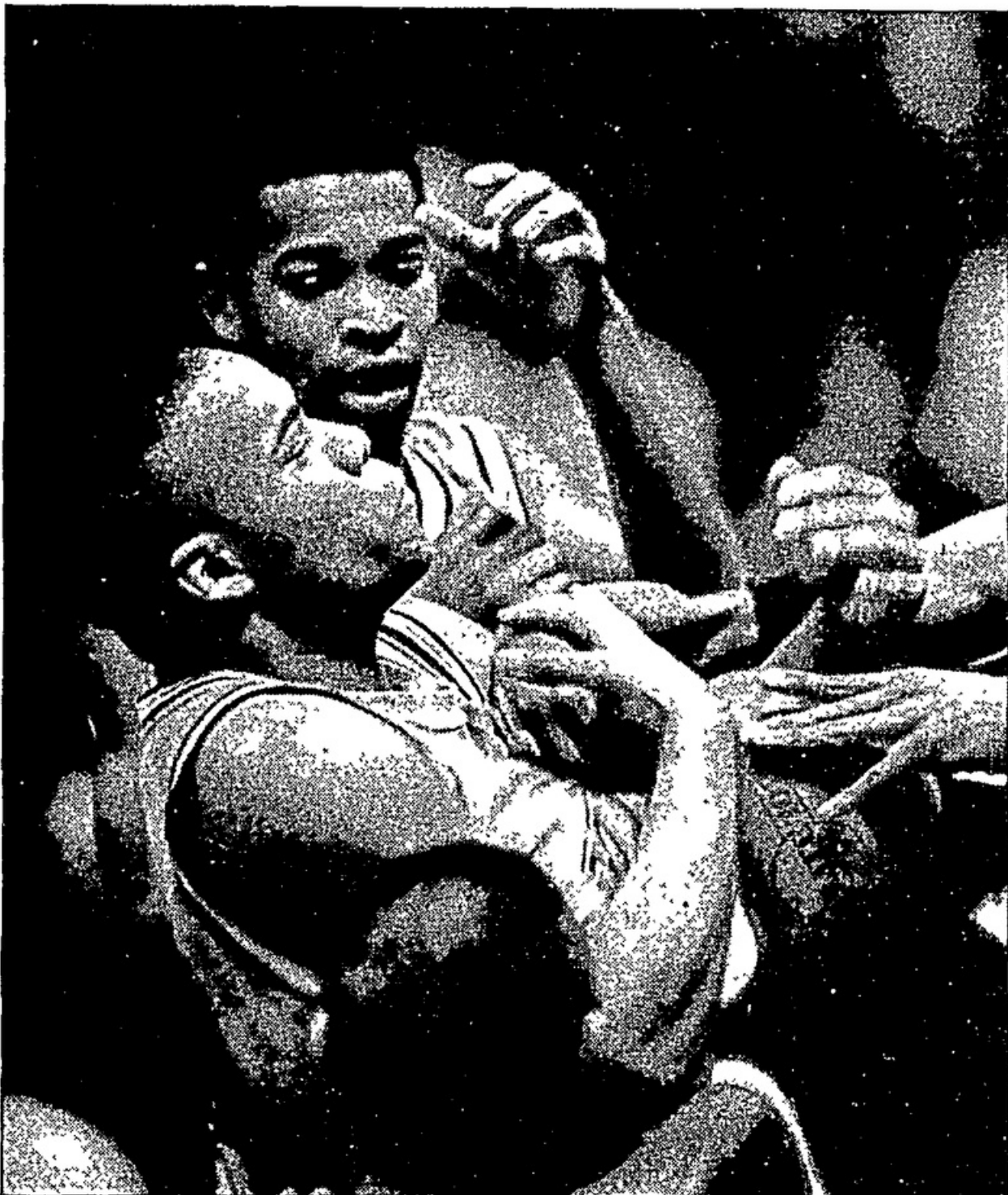
“ We took Stacey and his team out of rhythm. We had constant pressure, and we played an overall better second half. ”

Lorain coach John Rositano

of his 20 first-half points in the last minute of the first quarter, including a 3-pointer in the closing seconds to give Midview a 15-8 lead.

Lorain tried to fight back, getting within 5 points at 22-17 with 40 seconds left in the half. Again Stacey hit a last-second trey to keep the Middies up by eight, 25-17.

In the third quarter, the Steelmen made their assault. They held Midview to six points in the



HOARDING BOARDS — Midview's Anthony Stacey fights for one of his 22 rebounds against Lorain last night.

stanza, all the while scoring points of their own. With two seconds left, Adam Lucas layed in the go-ahead basket, to put Lorain ahead, 33-31 going into the final period.

"We took Stacey and his team out of rhythm," said Rositano. "We had constant pressure, and we played an overall better second half."

The Steelmen were able to stave off the Middies in the fourth quarter, and they held Stacey to

only 4 second-half points. Midview came within 1 with 22 seconds left, but two foul shots by Lorain's Greg Williams put the game out of reach.

Williams led The Steelmen with 18 points, and Lucas finished with 11.

Stacey would lead all players with 24 points in a losing effort for the Middies.

Next for Lorain will be the No. 2 seeded Westlake Demons on Wednesday at 7:00.

Elyria West to battle Rockets

By JIM HORVATH
Morning Journal Correspondent

BEREA — One can always expect a number of upsets on the road to the boys state basketball tournament in Columbus.

But there's nothing upsetting about that to Bay's Dick Scott or Elyria West's Steve Mohr.

Bay needed overtime but got past third seeded Keystone, 34-48, and Elyria West followed the Rockets' lead with a 60-57 win over the second seed, Parma Padua, in yesterday afternoon's Division II Sectional finals at Baldwin-Wallace College's Upsprung Gymnasium.

The Rockets, now 12-9, will face the 10-12 Wolverines Wednesday night at 8 p.m. at Upsprung in the district semifinals. And both, as you might expect, were happy with their invitations.

"I didn't know winning could be so much fun," beamed Scott, who saw his Rockets outscore Keystone 6-0 in the overtime period. "I'm ecstatic!"

Mohr was a bit more subdued, but one could not mistake the happiness he had for his squad.

"We're one of the 64 Division II teams left, and I'm tickled to death for the kids," he said. "These kids have come so far in so many ways. I'm proud of them, because no one has any idea how far they've come since the beginning of the year."

Bay used its traditional 3-point attack to earn a slim 28-27 lead by halftime. But in the second half, Keystone's defense kept the

trey's to a minimum and began going inside to Jason Rodak and Rob Beckham.

The Rockets countered with an inside game of their own against the spread out Wildcat defense as Michael Masterson went to work in the paint. At the end of regulation, a Beckham bucket gave Keystone a 48-46 lead with 1:19 left, but Ryan Scott tied it with a layup in the final minute to force the overtime.

In the extra period, Keystone missed all 7 of its shots. The 'Cats were also without Rodak, who fouled out midway through the fourth. Masterson hit the tie-breaker with 2:14 left for Bay, then went 4 of 6 from the foul line to ice it for the Rockets.

Frank Garrity led the Rockets with 14 points, while Masterson and Bob Miller chipped in with 14 points each. Rodak and Beckham had 13 and 10 points, respectively, for the Wildcats.

The Wolverines, meanwhile, battered Padua on even terms in the first half with the score 10-10 after one period and 28-28 at the intermission.

But West went on a roll in the third as Nate Crutcher and Robert Woolbright each scored 6 points while Daimion Mahone and Jason Woodyard nailed 3-pointers. The Wolverines took a 47-38 lead into the final period and led by as many as 10, 50-40, on another Mahone trey.

Mahone had 15 points and Crutcher 14 for West, while Woolbright added 11 points and 9 rebounds off the bench.

Falls, River wash away foes

By JIM HORVATH
Morning Journal Correspondent

BEREA — After the dust had settled at last night's Division II sectional finals, the only seeded team left standing was Olmsted Falls.

Just barely.

The top-seeded Bulldogs, saved by a miracle jumper at the end of regulation by Matt Tabar, got past Firelands 77-72 in overtime. Then in the nightcap, Rocky River jumped all over cold-shooting Avon Lake and dumped the fourth-seeded Shoremen, 63-49, at Baldwin-Wallace College's Upsprung Gymnasium.

Falls will now take on the Pirates in the district semifinals Wednesday at Upsprung at 6:30 p.m. The district final will be Saturday, March 11 at 7 p.m.

"We had them," said a dejected Firelands coach Mike Horne, whose team trailed 49-43 going into the fourth period but rallied to take a 63-62 lead with 1:01 left on a tip-in by Joe Potts.

But Falls big man Tim Schaefer, who led everyone with 31 points, hit the front end of a one-

and-one to tie it at 63 with 43 ticks left. Firelands' Rick Beran regained the lead for his team with a pair of free throws with 15 seconds left.

Then came the Bulldog dramatics.

After Potts had blocked a Falls shot out of bounds, Tabar took the inbound pass, drove from the left wing into traffic and threw up a prayer. The ball rolled in, out, around twice and through the hoop as the buzzer sounded to send the game into overtime.

In the OT, both teams traded free throws until Schaefer hit a baseline jumper to give Falls a 68-66 lead. The 'Dogs hit 5 of 6 free throws down the stretch and got big buckets from Schaefer and Nick Neumeister to keep the Falcons at bay.

"Everytime I thought we'd regain the lead they'd manage to hit their free throws," said Horne, whose team bows out at 9-13. "We had some stretches too where we had some cold shooting and turned the ball over."

"I'm happy with the way these guys battled back tonight. But

the winds were in Falls favor tonight," he added.

Matt Varnedell led the Falcons with 27 points, while Potts had 15 points and 10 rebounds. Mike Collier also hit double figures for Firelands with 12 points before fouling out late in the fourth quarter.

In the second game, Avon Lake led 29-24 at halftime but got scorched 17-5 in the third quarter by River, which advances with a 9-13 record. Ryan Crane had 9 points in that run for River, which shot 51 percent from the field for the game.

The Shoremen, finished for the year at 11-11, made just 2 of 12 field goal attempts in the period and just 5 of 16 in the fourth. The Pirates missed 5 front ends of one-and-ones in the fourth, but the power outage continued for Avon Lake at Terry Urig, Sean Deasy and Tom Koprowski all fouled out of the game in the final minute of play.

Deasy led Avon Lake with 12 points, while Urig and Jason Hurbanc each had 10. River got 14 from Chris Oatley, 13 from Crane and 10 from Chad Standing.

Spartans win; Avon grounded

By JAMES BRADY
Morning Journal Correspondent

STRONGSVILLE — The Lorain Catholic Spartans and the Avon Eagles each played some of their best basketball of the year in the Division IV Sectional Finals at Strongsville High School last night.

Unfortunately for Avon it wasn't enough as they fell to the second seeded Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy Royals 73-69 in the nightcap.

The Spartans held off a spectacular rally by the Kidron Central Christian Crusaders in the opener as they knocked them off 54-45.

The Spartans almost blew a 29-8 halftime lead in the second half as LC went cold from the field and just as cold from the free throw line.

The Spartans were on fire in the first half as they held the Crusaders without a field goal in the opening period and just 2 of 22 (9 percent) in the opening half.

Ron Mantini was at the heart of the first-half show scoring 11 of his game-high 21 points in the half. Mantini also pulled down 11 rebounds and blocked 4 shots in the opening two periods.

Central Christian settled down and played the Spartans even in the third and then exploded in the fourth with an 11-0 run to trim the LC lead to 48-39 on 7 straight Doug Geiser points, including 2 straight 3-pointers.

LC didn't help their own cause in the final quarter hitting 8 of 17 (47 percent) from the charity stripe and just 7 of 24 (29 percent)

from the field. The Spartans finally clamped down late in the game and escaped as time ran out on the Crusaders.

"We were the living example that teams can comeback with 3-point shots when you can't make free throws," said LC head coach Jim Lawhead. "They (Central) played zone and we just chopped it up in the first half. They came out and played man in the second half, which we wanted them too, and we couldn't get anything done. But, we hung on and won."

The Spartans will face the No. 2 seed, Cuyahoga Valley Christian Academy, in the Division IV District semi-finals on Tuesday at 8:00 p.m. back at Strongsville High School.

Lorain Catholic almost was looking at a rematch with the Avon Eagles, but Avon fell just short in pulling the upset against the Royals.

The Eagles played one of their best games of the year.

Freshman Steve Vega led all scorers in the game with 27 points. Josh Guerrieri and Troy Duesler also reached double-figures with 16 and 15 points respectively.

"That quite possibly could have been our best effort of the year," said Eagles head coach Dave Kudela. "It's tough to come back from double-digits. We did a great job of coming back to have a chance to win at the end."

Avon came out cool and confident as they moved out to a 19-18 first quarter lead with a 9-0 run to close the period, with Vega scoring the last 7 points of the spree.

Neither team held a lead of more than 5 points in the second

quarter as Cuyahoga Valley took a 37-34 lead at the half on a Matt Giovannini 3-pointer at the buzzer.

The Royals put themselves in a good position to win as they opened the second half with a 13-5 run to take a 50-39 advantage.

Vega pulled the Eagles back to within 56-50 at the end of the period with 9 points in the final three minutes of the quarter. Avon continued their comeback in the final quarter but could get over the hump as they two front ends of one and one's late in the game to keep them from pulling the upset.

"It's going to be fun to watch him (Vega) grow as a high school player," said Kudela. "He's fabulous to sit and watch and he really gives you a good show. He just has a knack of putting the ball in the hole. He just finds a way to get things done."

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